

THE FIVE-PHASE ARC

O I Read the system

Understanding the organisation as it actually runs

DESCRIPTION

Before any recommendation, the real constraints need to be visible – not the org chart, but how decisions actually get made, where authority sits, and what's already been tried. This phase is about listening long enough to see the system clearly, not confirming what's already assumed.

KEY ACTIVITIES

- Stakeholder conversations across business, technology and the board
- Review of existing strategy, architecture and governance documents
- Mapping of decision rights, dependencies and known constraints
- Technical and operational due diligence where relevant
- Synthesis of findings into a single, shared picture

TIMEFRAME

Days to weeks, depending on engagement scope

DELIVERABLES

- Written findings summary
- A single view of the system as it actually operates

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02 Name what's true

An honest assessment, stated plainly

DESCRIPTION

The findings go to the board or founder directly, including the parts that are uncomfortable – no softened language, no burying the real risk in a longer list of minor ones. This is the phase most engagements shorten; it's the one that makes everything after it useful.

KEY ACTIVITIES

- Structuring findings into a clear, evidenced assessment
- Naming the two or three things that matter most, not twenty
- A direct conversation with the board, founder or sponsor
- Agreeing what "true" means before moving to a plan

TIMEFRAME

Typically a single session, once the diagnostic is complete

DELIVERABLES

- Board-ready assessment
- A shared, agreed statement of the real problem

THE FIVE-PHASE ARC

03 Set the direction

A plan that's sequenced and resourced

DESCRIPTION

Direction only means something once it's been tested against what the organisation can actually deliver. This phase turns the assessment into a plan — priorities in order, resourcing implications made explicit, and a sequence that reflects real capacity rather than an ideal timeline.

KEY ACTIVITIES

- Prioritising against impact, risk and delivery capacity
- Building a phased roadmap with realistic sequencing
- Identifying capability, resourcing and governance gaps
- Testing the plan with the people who'll have to deliver it

TIMEFRAME

One to two weeks

DELIVERABLES

- Sequenced roadmap
- Resourcing and capability plan

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04 Lead the change

Embedded leadership, not a handover of slides

DESCRIPTION

This is where most technology advice fails – the plan is handed over and the advisor leaves. Here, the leadership continues: embedded in the organisation, making the calls, adjusting the plan as reality intervenes, and carrying accountability for the outcome rather than the recommendation.

KEY ACTIVITIES

- Fractional or interim leadership of the delivery effort
- Day-to-day decision-making within the agreed mandate
- Regular reporting to the board or sponsor
- Course correction as the programme meets reality

TIMEFRAME

Ongoing – weeks to months, set by the mandate

DELIVERABLES

- Delivery against the agreed roadmap
- Regular, honest progress reporting

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05 Leave it capable

A deliberate handover, on purpose

DESCRIPTION

The engagement ends by design, not by attrition. Capability, decisions and context are handed back to the organisation deliberately, so the work doesn't quietly need me again next year. This is what separates fractional leadership from consultancy dependency.

KEY ACTIVITIES

- Documenting decisions, rationale and open risks
- Transferring capability to the team taking over
- Formal handover to the board or successor
- Agreeing what "done" looks like before leaving

TIMEFRAME

Final one to two weeks of the engagement

DELIVERABLES

- Documented handover pack
- A capable team, not a dependency

*Most engagements begin with a single conversation. No obligation
— the right fit matters more than the right brochure.*

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